SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #59 · FEAR AND THE NEWS

"I must stay on guard all the time."

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Where it often comes from

Past betrayal, trauma, or a chaotic home taught that relaxing leads to harm. Hypervigilance feels like protection, but it exhausts the body and mind, strains relationships, and keeps us from rest.

What Scripture teaches

Psalm 127 reminds us that unless the LORD guards the city, the watchman stays alert in vain. Scripture also says, "The LORD will guard you from all evil... The LORD will watch over your coming and going." "You will keep in perfect peace the steadfast of mind, because he trusts in You." "I will lie down and sleep in peace, for You alone, O LORD, make me dwell in safety." Wise caution is good, but constant guarding is a burden God did not design us to carry. He is the One who never slumbers.

> *"You will keep in perfect peace the steadfast of mind, because he trusts in You"* (Isaiah 26:3).

Also see

> "The LORD will guard you from all evil; He will preserve your soul. The LORD will watch over your coming and going, both now and forevermore" (Psalm 121:7–8).

> "I will lie down and sleep in peace, for You alone, O LORD, make me dwell in safety" (Psalm 4:8).

> "Do not fear sudden danger or the ruin that overtakes the wicked, for the LORD will be your confidence and will keep your foot from the snare" (Proverbs 3:25–26).

> "Let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, for to this you were called as members of one body. And be thankful" (Colossians 3:15).

Common self-statements

- If I relax, something bad happens.
- I have to watch everything.
- Letting my guard down is dangerous.
- Peace is naive.
- I am the only protector.
- I am always bracing.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must be on guard or unsafe.
- Mind reading: Assuming danger around every corner.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling tense and concluding that danger is near.
- Fortune telling: Predicting harm if I relax.

Challenging questions

- What taught me to stay on guard?
- What has constant vigilance cost me?

- What actual dangers need attention, and what do not?
- What does it mean that God watches over me?
- What helps my body relax?
- Who or what is safe enough to rest with?

Truth summary

> God watches over me, so I do not have to watch alone. I can use wise caution where needed and practice rest. Perfect peace comes from trusting Him.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Peace
- Anxiety/Worry
- Sleep Problems
- Tired
- Fear

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must stay on guard all the time"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must stay on guard all the time." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What taught me this?
- ☐ What has it cost?
- ☐ What dangers are real?
- ☐ What does God's watching mean?
- ☐ What helps me relax?
- ☐ Where can I rest?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God watches over my coming and going.
- ☐ He keeps me in perfect peace.
- ☐ I can sleep in peace.
- ☐ The Lord is my confidence.
- ☐ I can use wise caution and rest.
- ☐ I am not the only protector.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Isaiah 26:3
  "You will keep in perfect peace the steadfast of mind, because he trusts in You."
- ☐ Psalm 121:7–8
  "The LORD will guard you from all evil; He will preserve your soul. The LORD will watch over your coming and going, both now and forevermore."
- ☐ Psalm 4:8
  "I will lie down and sleep in peace, for You alone, O LORD, make me dwell in safety."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Rest in His watch: Each day, practice five minutes of rest and thank God for watching over you.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Isaiah 26:3 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God keeps me in perfect peace when I trust in Him.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Peace" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Notice the guard. Write when your body tenses.
- [ ] Practice rest. Breathe, stretch, or pray for five minutes.
- [ ] Sort dangers. List real risks and imagined ones.
- [ ] Seek help. If this comes from trauma, talk with a counselor.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must stay on guard all the time": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Rest in His watch
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must stay on guard all the time.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I am tired of standing guard. You never slumber. Teach me to trust Your watching and to rest in Your peace. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.